
RIGHT AWAY, WE WENT. THE SANITARIUM WAS INSIDE CZECHOSLOVAKIA, ONE OF THE MOST EXPENSIVE AND BEAUTIFUL IN THE WORLD.
I REMEMBER WHEN WE WERE ALMOST ARRIVED, WE PASSED A SMALL TOWN.
OI!
EVERYBODY - EVERY JEW FROM THE TRAIN - GOT VERY EXCITED AND FRIGHTENED.
LOOK!
IT WAS THE BEGINNING OF 1938 - BEFORE THE WAR - HANGING HIGH IN THE CENTER OF TOWN, IT WAS A NAZI FLAG..
HERE WAS THE FIRST TIME I SAW, WITH MY OWN EYES, THE SWASTIKA.


I TELL YOU, THERE'S A POGROM GOING ON IN GERMANY TODAY!
ONE FELLOW TOLD US OF HIS COUSIN WHAT WAS LIVING IN GERMANY...


...HE HAD TO SELL HIS BUSINESS TO A GERMAN AND RUN OUT FROM THE COUNTRY WITHOUT EVEN THE MONEY.


I AM A FILTHY JEW
IT WAS VERY HARD THERE FOR THE JEWS-TERRIBLE!


ANOTHER FELLOW TOLD US OF A RELATIVE IN BRANDENBERG-THE POLICE CAME TO HIS HOUSE AND NO ONE HEARD AGAIN FROM HIM.


This town is Jew Free
IT WAS MANY, MANY SUCH STORIES-SYNAGOGUES BURNED, JEWS BEATEN WITH NO REASON, WHOLE TOWNS PUSHING OUT ALL JEWS-EACH STORY WORSE THAN THE OTHER.


LET'S HOPE THOSE NAZI GANGSTERS GET THROWN OUT OF POWER!
JUST PRAY THAT THEY DON'T START A WAR!!


THE SANITARIUM WAS FAR AWAY FROM EVERYTHING— SO PEACEFUL, SO QUIET.
LOOK AT HOW BEAUTIFUL THESE GARDENS ARE, ANJA.
UH HUH
PEOPLE CAME FROM ALL OVER THE WORLD WITH DIFFERENT SICKNESSES. IT WAS EVEN SHOPS HERE... A THEATER... REALLY BEAUTIFUL...
OUR ROOM IS LIKE A LUXURY HOTEL—LOOK AT THIS VIEW.
UH HUH
EACH MORNING NURSES WOULD VISIT TO ANJA.
AND EACH FEW DAYS I TALKED TO THE BIG SPECIALIST AT THE CLINIC.
WELL, WHAT DID THE DOCTOR SAY!?
HE TOLD ME YOU'RE DOING FINE... FINE..
JUST RELAX.
I UNDERSTOOD MUCH OF SUCH SICKNESSES, SO I HELPED ALWAYS TO CALM HER DOWN.
LOOK—WE GOT A LETTER FROM HOME TODAY.
WITH A PHOTO OF RICHIEU—LET ME SEE.
HE'S A HANDSOME BOY... JUST LIKE HIS FATHER, YES?
YES.















AND SHE WAS SO LAUGHING AND SO HAPPY, SO HAPPY, THAT SHE APPROACHED EACH TIME AND KISSED ME, SO HAPPY SHE WAS.


WE STAYED MAYBE 3 MONTHS, AND WHEN WE CAME BACK, ANJA WAS COMPLETELY DIFFERENT FROM WHEN SHE LEFT.
YOO HOO, POPPA!
ANJA! YOU LOOK LIKE A MILLION!
LISTEN, VLADEK... I DIDN'T WANT YOU TO WORRY WHILE YOU WERE AT THE SANITARIUM, BUT -
-BRACE YOURSELF- THE BIELSKO FACTORY HAS BEEN ROBBED!
WHAT!
IT HAPPENED LAST MONTH. THEY TOOK EVERYTHING!
AI! AI! AI!
I DIDN'T EVEN HAVE TIME TO INSURE IT BEFORE WE LEFT.
WELL, AT LEAST I CAN HELP YOU BUILD IT UP AGAIN.
WERE YOU LOOTED AS PART OF SOME KIND OF ANTI-SEMITIC ACTIVITY?
I DON'T THINK THIS WAS IT. JUST A ROBBERY...
...LIKE WHEN THEY ROBBED US IN REGO PARK HERE, LAST YEAR.
WELL... IN BIELSKO, FATHER-IN-LAW HELPED US AGAIN TO ESTABLISH OURSELVES ...


IN A COUPLE MONTHS WE WERE WELL-OFF— QUITE WELL-OFF... A WORKING FACTORY, A 2 BEDROOM APARTMENT, A POLISH GOVERNESS, AND EVEN A MAID.
LOOK, RICHIEU, POPPA'S HOME!
YOU LOOK UPSET, VLADEK.
THERE WAS ANOTHER RIOT DOWNTOWN TODAY.
...EVERYONE YELLING, "JEWS OUT! JEWS OUT!"... EVEN TWO PEOPLE KILLED. THE POLICE JUST WATCHED!
IT'S THOSE NAZIS STIRRING EVERYBODY UP!
WHEN IT COMES TO JEWS, THE POLES DON'T NEED MUCH STIRRING UP!
MRS. SPIEGELMAN— HOW CAN YOU SAY SUCH A THING. I THINK OF YOU AS PART OF MY OWN FAMILY!
I'M SORRY, JANINA— I DIDN'T MEAN YOU! I'M JUST WORRIED!
MAYBE WE SHOULD MOVE AWAY, LIKE SOME OTHERS HAVE.
IF THINGS GET REALLY BAD WE'LL RUN BACK TO SOSNOWIEC.
WHY WOULD SOSNOWIEC BE ANY SAFER THAN BIELSKO?
WE THOUGHT THEN, THAT HITLER WANTED ONLY THE PARTS FROM POLAND, LIKE BIELSKO, WHAT USED TO BE PARTS FROM GERMANY BEFORE THE FIRST WORLD WAR.


WE WERE VERY HAPPY, STILL, FOR OVER A YEAR - UNTIL AUGUST 24, 1939.
A LETTER - FROM THE GOVERNMENT!


A DRAFT NOTICE! I WAS IN THE POLISH RESERVES ARMY, AND SO I HAD TO GO RIGHT AWAY!


IT WAS A BIG CONFUSION... EVERYONE KNEW IT WOULD BE NOW A WAR...
QUICK! PACK EVERYTHING! YOUR FATHER WILL TAKE YOU TO SOSNOWIEC.
VLADEK, I'M AFRAID!


GRAB YOUR KNICK-KNACKS, AND THE DOLL COLLECTION!
THEY'RE NOT IMPORTANT!
YOU'LL SEE. YOU MAY ENJOY THEM.
I WAS RIGHT. WHEN THINGS WENT WORSE LATER, SHE WAS ABLE TO SELL SUCH THINGS.


SO ANJA AND RICHIEU AND THE GOVERNESS WENT IN ONE WAY — TO SOSNOWIEC...


... AND I WENT THEN IN A DIFFERENT DIRECTION... TO THE FRONTIER AGAINST GERMANY.


AND THE WORK WAS REALLY VERY HARD- WE HAD TO MOVE MOUNTAINS.
MOUNTAIN
VALLEY
THE HILLS WERE MAYBE 3 OR 4 YARDS HIGH. WE HAD TO MAKE IT LEVEL.
SOME COMPLAINED - THOSE WHAT WERE TOO OLD OR WEAK FOR SUCH WORK:
I-I CAN'T TAKE ANYMORE.
WORTHLESS JEW!
IF YOU'RE UNHAPPY - GO BACK TO THE P.O.W. CAMP.
IT'S OKAY - WE'LL HELP YOU WHEN NO ONE IS LOOKING.
WE TRIED TO HELP, BUT - WHAT YOU THINK? - SOME WENT BACK TO THE TENTS TO FREEZE AND TO STARVE.
BUT WHAT HAPPENED TO THEM, I DON'T KNOW.
STILL, EIGHTY PER CENT STAYED. THERE WAS ENOUGH TO EAT, AND A WARM BED. IT WAS BETTER TO STAY...

...ALWAYS I WENT TO SLEEP EXHAUSTED. AND ONE NIGHT I HAD A DREAM...

A VOICE WAS TALKING TO ME. IT WAS, I THINK, MY DEAD GRANDFATHER...

"DON'T WORRY...

"...DON'T WORRY, MY CHILD..."

IT WAS SO REAL, THIS VOICE...

"YOU WILL COME OUT OF THIS PLACE - FREE! ...ON THE DAY OF PARSHAS TRUMA."

I WOKE UP RIGHT AWAY. AND WHEN I WENT TO SLEEP, AGAIN IT WAS: "PARSHAS TRUMA! PARSHAS TRUMA!"

SO WHAT'S PARSHAS TRUMA?

EACH WEEK, ON SATURDAY, WE READ A SECTION FROM THE TORAH.

THIS IS SO CALLED - A PARSHA... AND ONE WEEK EACH YEAR IT IS PARSHAS TRUMA.

BEFORE WORK A FEW FROM US PRAYED. IT WAS A RABBI THERE WITH US.

ONE MOMENT, RABBI. WHEN WILL WE READ PARSHAS TRUMA?

PARSHAS TRUMA?..

...IN THE MIDDLE OF FEBRUARY - ALMOST THREE MONTHS FROM NOW. WHY?

THREE MONTHS - AND EVERY DAY WAS FOR US A YEAR!

I TOLD HIM MY DREAM...

LET'S HOPE IT'S TRUE. I'M AFRAID WE'LL NEVER GET OUT OF HERE.


SO WE WORKED, DAY AFTER DAY. WE SURVIVED. WEEK AFTER WEEK. THE SAME.


UNTIL, ONE TIME...
LOOK - SOLDIERS!


IT CAME VERY MANY GESTAPO AND WEHRMACHT.
ATTENTION! LINE UP ON THE ROAD IN TWO ROWS! IMMEDIATELY!
WE WERE NOT AT EASE. WE DIDN'T KNOW WHAT THEY COULD DO WITH US.


I STOOD ALWAYS IN THE SECOND LINE.
(PSST - VLADEK.)
I DIDN'T WANT THEY SHOULD SEE ME MUCH.


SOMEONE SNEAKED NEXT TO ME...
RABBI!
DO YOU KNOW WHAT DAY IT IS?


SATURDAY, OF COURSE.
BUT DO YOU KNOW WHAT A SATURDAY?...


IT'S PARSHAS TRUMA!


THEY MARCHED US TO THE MAIN COURTYARD AND LINED US BY ALPHABET AT TABLES...
NAME AND RANK?
SPIEGELMAN, VLADEK. CORPORAL.


DESTINATION UPON RELEASE?
SOSNOWIEC.
THIS THE GERMANS DID VERY GOOD...


...TO MY WIFE AND CHILD.
...ALWAYS THEY DID EVERYTHING VERY SYSTEMATIC.

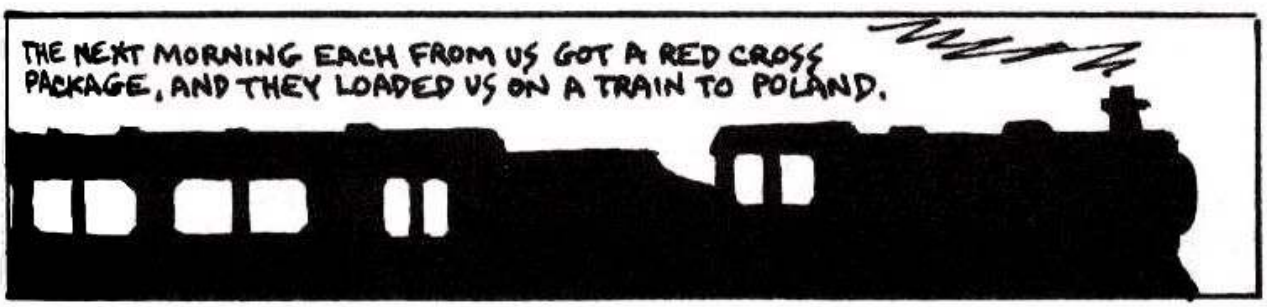

VERY WELL - SIGN THIS RELEASE FORM.
...AND IT WAS ALL DONE IN ONE DAY.


YOU MEAN YOUR 'PARSHAS TRUMA' DREAM ACTUALLY CAME TRUE?
YES - THIS IS FOR ME A VERY IMPORTANT DATE...


I CHECKED LATER ON A CALENDAR. IT WAS THIS PARSHA ON THE WEEK I GOT MARRIED TO ANJA.


...AND THIS WAS THE PARSHA IN 1948, AFTER THE WAR, ON THE WEEK YOU WERE BORN!..


AND SO IT CAME OUT TO BE THIS PARSHA YOU SANG ON THE SATURDAY OF YOUR BAR MITZVAH!


THE NEXT MORNING EACH FROM US GOT A RED CROSS PACKAGE, AND THEY LOADED US ON A TRAIN TO POLAND.

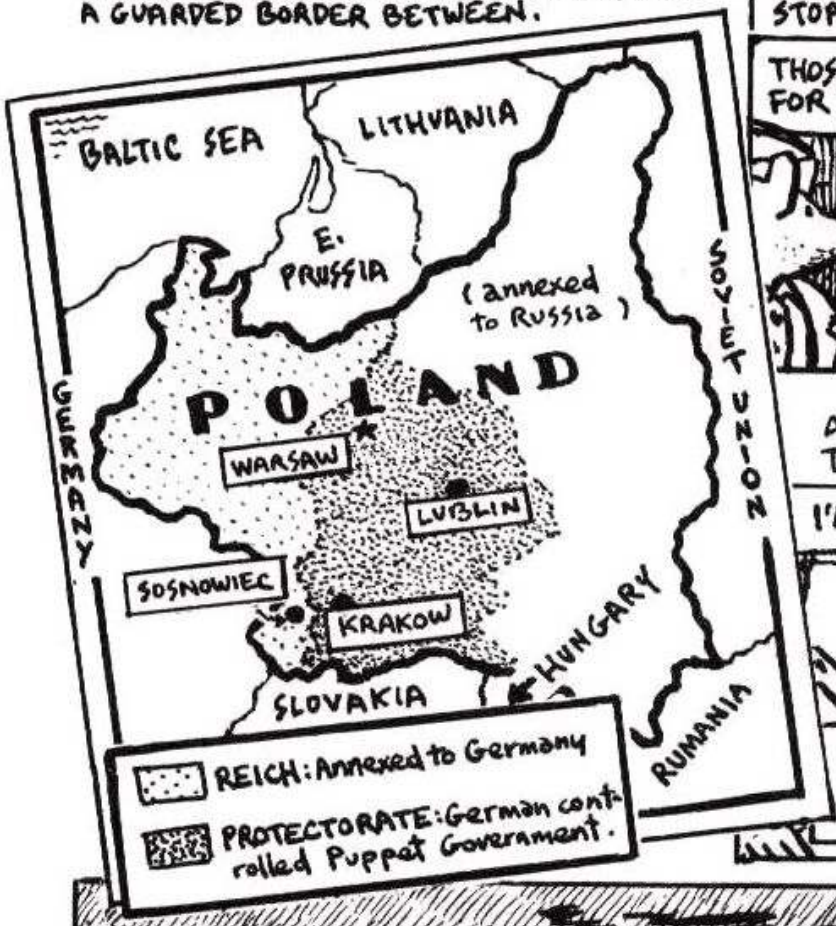
DURING THE JOURNEY I SAT WITH THE RABBI.

SO, MY SON. NOW I SEE YOU ARE A "ROH-EH HANOLED," ONE WHO SEES WHAT THE FUTURE WILL BRING.

HEY! THIS TRAIN SEEMS TO BE PASSING SOSNOWIEC!

WHEN THEY DIDN'T STOP THE TRAIN I BECAME VERY WORRIED.

YOU SEE, THE NAZIS DIVIDED POLAND INTO PIECES: PROTECTORATE AND REICH, WITH A GUARDED BORDER BETWEEN.



THE TRAIN WENT COMPLETELY PAST MY PART OF POLAND - THE REICH - AND STOPPED ONLY IN THE PROTECTORATE.

THOSE WITH PAPERS FOR KRAKOW - OUT!

AND, WHEN IT STOPPED IN WARSAW, THE RABBI GOT OUT.

I'LL WRITE TO YOU.

BUT I NEVER HEARD AGAIN FROM HIM. IT CAME SUCH A MISERY IN WARSAW, ALMOST NONE SURVIVED.

AND THE TRAIN WAS A LONG WAY PAST SOSNOWIEC. THEY TOOK ME UP, UP, VERY FAR - MAYBE 300 MILES - UNTIL WE CAME TO LUBLIN. THERE THEY UNLOADED ALL OF US FROM THE REICH.


IN LUBLIN, THEY TOOK US TO BIG TENTS..
AND THERE WE SAT.
EVENTUALLY CAME SOME PEOPLE TO SEE US FROM THE JEWISH AUTHORITIES...
WHY ARE WE BEING KEPT HERE?
IT'S A VERY BAD SITUATION... JUST BEFORE YOU ARRIVED, THERE WAS ANOTHER GROUP OF RELEASED WAR PRISONERS...
...TWO DAYS AGO THE NAZIS MARCHED THEM TO A FOREST,...
...AND THEY SHOT ALL OF THEM-THEY KILLED 600 PEOPLE!
WE WERE THE NEXT PARTY!
I THOUGHT YOU WERE RELEASED AS A PRISONER OF WAR!
EXACTLY SO..
INTERNATIONAL LAWS PROTECTED US A LITTLE AS POLISH WAR PRISONERS. BUT A JEW OF THE REICH, ANYONE COULD KILL IN THE STREETS!


I WAS VERY FRIGHTENED.
THEN WE HEARD SOMETHING TO GIVE US A LITTLE HOPE...
WE'VE BRIBED THE GERMANS TO RELEASE PRISONERS INTO THE HOMES OF LOCAL JEWS WHO WILL CLAIM YOU AS RELATIVES.
MY NAME'S SPIEGELMAN. THERE'S A FRIEND OF MY FAMILY NAMED ORBACH IN LUBLIN. I MET HIM WHEN I WAS HERE FOR ARMY TRAINING.
FINE! WE'LL TRY TO REGISTER YOU AS HIS COUSIN.
THAT NIGHT I WENT OUT FROM THE TENT.
I HAD TO URINATE.
I RAN QUICK INSIDE ....
AND THOUGHT ALL NIGHT DIFFERENT THINGS WHAT COULD HAPPEN TO US.
ZING
AND A GUARD BEGAN SHOOTING TO ME.


THEN AS SOON AS IT WAS LIGHT..
SPIEGELMAN!.. SPIEGELMAN!..
VLADEK!
ORBACH! AM I GLAD TO SEE YOU!
AND IN TEN MINUTES, I WAS FREE!
ORBACH WAS A FRIEND FROM MY UNCLE- HE HAD TWO BEAUTIFUL DAUGHTERS NEAR TO MY AGE.
I'M SORRY WE CAN'T OFFER YOU A BETTER MEAL, VLADEK – BUT THE JEWS OF LUBLIN GET VERY FEW FOOD COUPONS.
ONE MOMENT, GIRLS-I HAVE A GIFT FOR EACH OF YOU...
OH MY GOD! CHOCOLATE!
THESE I SAVED FROM A RED CROSS PACKAGE. ALWAYS I SAVED... JUST IN CASE!
EVENTUALLY, WHEN I CAME AGAIN TO SOSNOWIEC, WE SENT THEM FOOD PACKAGES...
... WE WERE FOR A WHILE A LITTLE BETTER OFF... AND THEY WROTE BACK VERY HAPPY HOW IT HELPED SURVIVE THEM...
...THEN THEY WROTE THAT THE GERMANS WERE KEEPING THE PACKAGES. AND THEN THEY STOPPED TO WRITE. FINISHED.
WITH ORBACHS' I STAYED A FEW DAYS RECUPERATING. BUT I WAS RESTLESS. HOW COULD I MANAGE TO SNEAK ACROSS THE BORDER TO MY FAMILY?

TRAINS WERE STILL GOING FROM PROTECTORATE TO REICH. ONLY, ONE NEEDED LEGAL PAPERS. OF COURSE. THIS I DIDN'T HAVE ...

...BUT ANYWAY I GOT ON THE TRAIN IN THE DIRECTION I WANTED.

I APPROACHED TO THE TRAIN MAN, A POLE...

MAY I TALK TO YOU FOR A MOMENT?

SURE, SOLDIER.

I STILL HAD ON MY ARMY UNIFORM, AND I DIDN'T LET KNOW I WAS A JEW.

YOU'RE A POLE LIKE ME, SO I CAN TRUST YOU... THE STINKING NAZIS HAD ME IN A WAR PRISON... I JUST ESCAPED.

THE POLES WERE VERY BITTER ON THE GERMANS; SO IT WAS GOOD TO SPEAK BAD OF THEM.

I'M TRYING TO GET TO SOSNOWIEC - BACK TO MY FAMILY.

DON'T WORRY... WHEN WE GET TO THE BORDER, HIDE IN HERE.

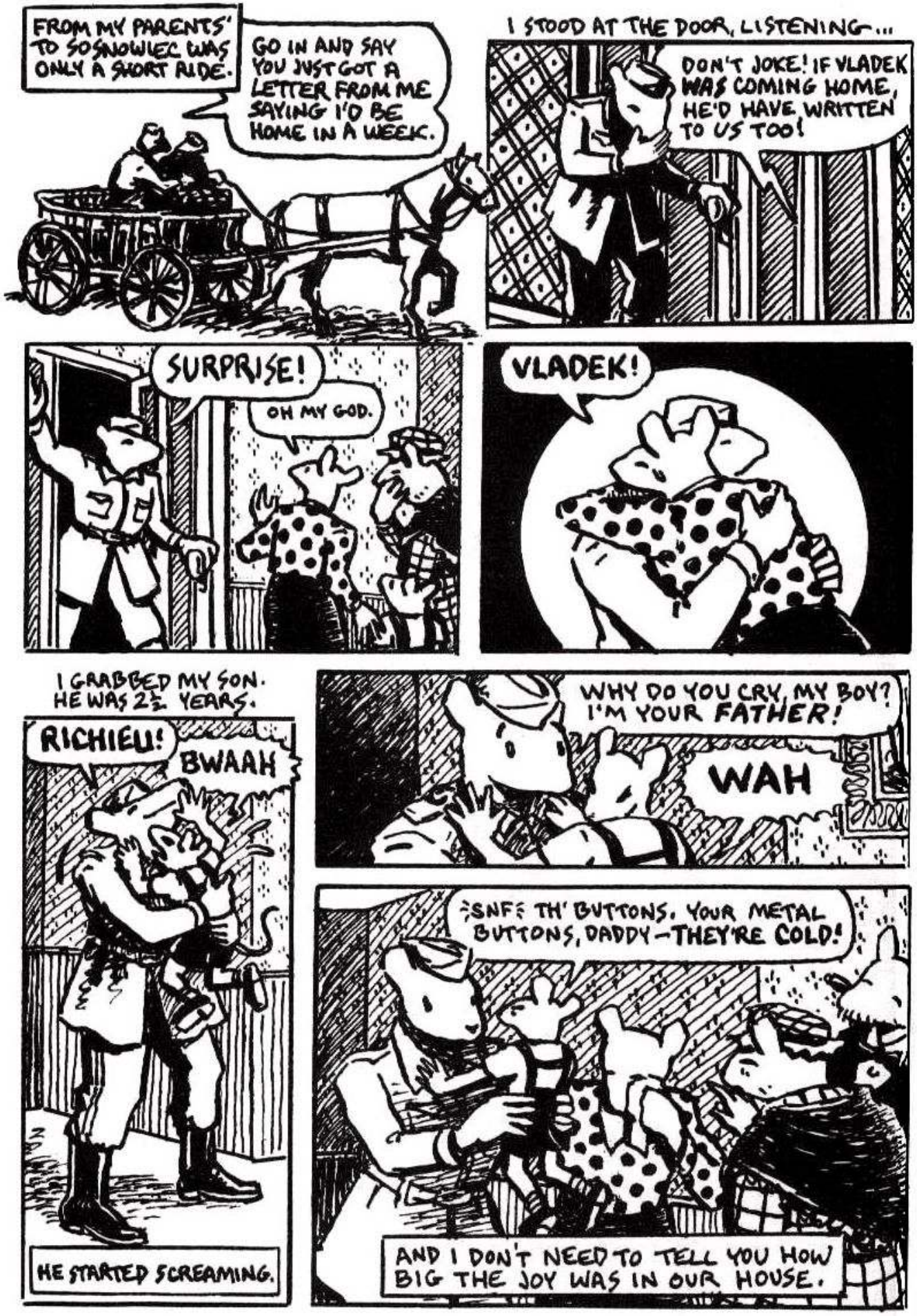
AND SO THE TRAIN MAN HELPED ME COME BACK TO MY SIDE OF POLAND.

I WALKED FIRST OVER TO MY PARENTS' HOUSE...

...WHAT I THOUGHT I MIGHT NEVER SEE AGAIN.

OY GEVALT! IT'S VLADEK!


MY SON! THANK GOD YOU'RE SAFE!
AND IN SPITE OF EVERYTHING, YOU LOOK HEALTHY!
I'M STRONG, MOTHER. BUT YOU LOOK SICK!
IT'S BECAUSE I WAS WORRIED ABOUT YOU.
BUT IT WASN'T ONLY THIS. SHE WAS SICK OF CANCER.
...AND A MONTH OR TWO LATER, SHE DIED.
SHE NEVER KNEW HOW TERRIBLE EVERYTHING WOULD SOON BE!
-AND, FATHER! YOUR BEARD! WHAT HAPPENED? YOU SHAVED IT OFF?!??
IT'S GROWING BACK, NOW...
HE WAS VERY RELIGIOUS - SO LIKE A RABBI - AND, OF COURSE, HE ALWAYS HAD A BIG BEARD.
IN SEPTEMBER THE GERMAN SOLDIERS GRABBED MANY JEWS IN THE STREET...
THEY MADE US SING PRAYERS WHILE THEY LAUGHED AND BEAT US.
...AND BEFORE LETTING US GO, THEY CUT OFF OUR BEARDS.
AND NOW THE DEMONS HAVE TAKEN AWAY MY SELTZER FACTORY. THEY—
ENOUGH!
I MUST BRING VLADEK HOME TO ANJA BEFORE CURFEW.
AT 7:00 IT WAS A RULE. ALL JEWS HAD TO BE IN THEIR HOME AND ALL LIGHTS OUT.


FROM MY PARENTS' TO SOSNOWIEC WAS ONLY A SHORT RIDE.
GO IN AND SAY YOU JUST GOT A LETTER FROM ME SAYING I'D BE HOME IN A WEEK.
I STOOD AT THE DOOR, LISTENING...
DON'T JOKE! IF VLADEK WAS COMING HOME, HE'D HAVE WRITTEN TO US TOO!
SURPRISE!
OH MY GOD.
VLADEK!
I GRABBED MY SON. HE WAS 2½ YEARS.
RICHIEU!
BWAAH
HE STARTED SCREAMING.
WHY DO YOU CRY, MY BOY? I'M YOUR FATHER!
WAH
SNIFF TH' BUTTONS. YOUR METAL BUTTONS, DADDY—THEY'RE COLD!
AND I DON'T NEED TO TELL YOU HOW BIG THE JOY WAS IN OUR HOUSE.


EVEN THOUGH EVERYTHING WAS VERY TOUGH—AND IT WAS REALLY VERY TOUGH—WE WERE HAPPY ONLY TO BE TOGETHER.
..NOT SO LIKE IT IS NOW WITH ME AND MALA.
I TELL YOU, IF ANJA COULD BE ALIVE NOW, IT WOULD BE EVERYTHING DIFFERENT WITH ME!
MALA MAKES ME CRAZY. ONLY SHE TALKS ABOUT MONEY. ALWAYS ABOUT MY WILL—
PLEASE, POP!...
YOU ALWAYS TELL ME THE SAME THINGS. THERE'S NOTHING I CAN DO.
BUT I HAVEN'T WITH WHOM ELSE TO TALK!
AND IT'S FOR YOU I WATCH OUT MY MONEY!
JEEZ—LET'S TALK ABOUT IT NEXT TIME. I'LL CALL YOU!
BESIDES, IT'S GETTING LATE. I OUGHTA GET HOME BEFORE CURFEW!"
HMF.
HEY—WHERE'S MY COAT? I KNOW I PUT IT IN HERE!


MALA, DID YOU PUT MY COAT SOMEPLACE?
NO. ARE YOU GOING NOW?..
X-WORD PUZZLE
I'LL MAKE YOU SOME COFFEE.
NO THANKS. I'M NOT THIRSTY...
...AND YOU MAKE THE WORST COFFEE I'VE EVER TASTED.
BUT I STILL HAVE THAT BAG OF ESPRESSO YOU ONCE LEFT HERE.
BUT THAT WAS OVER 6 MONTHS AGO. THAT COFFEE'S COMPLETELY STALE!
SO... MAYBE SOME TEA?
NO, THANKS. JUST MY COAT.
OH, DAD - HAVE YOU SEEN MY COAT ANYWHERE?
YES...
..I THREW IT OUT.
WHAT?!?
YOU'RE KIDDING!
sigh
GIVE IT BACK!
IT'S TOO LATE...
WHEN YOU WERE SITTING FIRST DOWN TO DINNER, I THREW IT OUTSIDE. BY NOW THE GARBAGE MEN TOOK IT AWAY.